

TID — The Instant Destroyer

A Linux Kernel Module for Cache Side-Channel Attack Protection

Research Paper — TID Project

Author	Ahmad Qasim Mohammad Hassan
ORCID	0009-0001-4360-0802
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Abstract

This paper presents TID (The Instant Destroyer), a Linux kernel module written in C designed to protect sensitive data from cache-based side-channel attacks, specifically the Flush+Reload attack.

The tool relies on specialized processor instructions: REP STOSQ for secure wiping, CLFLUSHOPT for cache eviction, and LFENCE/MFENCE to close speculative execution windows.

Experiments on real hardware (AMD EPYC 9B14, Linux 6.14.11) demonstrated that TID v2.0 raises attacker access latency from 78 cycles (Cache HIT) to 286 cycles (Cache MISS) — a 3.7x ratio — successfully defeating Flush+Reload after data use ends.

What distinguishes this work from existing libraries (libsodium, OpenSSL, glibc) is the universal absence of CLFLUSHOPT from all of them, making TID the only practical implementation of the PROTECT+ZERO protocol at kernel module level.

1 Introduction

As reliance on cloud computing and multi-tenant environments grows, side-channel attacks have become a real — not merely theoretical — threat. These attacks target sensitive data such as encryption keys, passwords, and session tokens after their use ends, exploiting their residual presence in cache memory.

The Flush+Reload attack (Yarom & Falkner, 2014) is the most prominent model: the attacker measures the timing difference between accessing a populated cache (~50–100 cycles) and an empty cache (~200–400 cycles), inferring whether targeted data was recently used.

Current software solutions (`explicit_bzero`, `memzero_explicit`, `sodium_memzero`) prevent the compiler from omitting wipe operations, but do not evict the cache. TID fills this gap by adding `CLFLUSHOPT` after wiping, accompanied by `LFENCE`/`MFENCE` barriers to prevent speculative execution.

2 Technical Background

2.1 The Flush+Reload Attack

The attack operates in three consecutive phases:

| a) Flush

The attacker evicts the target cache line (`CLFLUSH`).

| b) Use

The victim uses the data — it loads into the cache.

| c) Reload

The attacker measures re-access latency via `RDTSC`.

Scenario	Interpretation	Result
Short latency (Cache Hit ~78 cycles)	Data was in cache — victim used it	Leakage
Long latency (Cache Miss ~286 cycles)	Cache empty — nothing revealed	No information

2.2 Instructions Used in TID

| `REP STOSQ`

An x86 instruction that repeatedly writes zero values into memory blocks. The compiler cannot omit it — unlike `memset` — because it is a direct assembler instruction, not a C function.

| CLFLUSHOPT

Evicts a specific cache line from all cache levels (L1/L2/L3). Available on Intel Skylake (2015+) and AMD Zen 2+. Faster than CLFLUSH as it does not wait for completion.

| LFENCE (Load Fence)

Blocks speculative execution for subsequent instructions. Recommended by both Intel and AMD for side-channel attack mitigation.

| MFENCE (Memory Fence)

Ensures ordering of all memory read/write operations. Prevents reordering between instructions.

2.3 Existing Solutions and Their Shortcomings

Library	Safe Wipe	CLFLUSH	LFENCE
explicit_bzero() — glibc	Yes	No	No
memzero_explicit() — Linux Kernel	Yes	No	No
OPENSSL_cleanse() — OpenSSL	Yes	No	No
sodium_memzero() — libsodium	Yes	No	No
TID v2.0	Yes	Yes	Yes

Conclusion: No major security library evicts the cache after wiping data. TID fills this gap.

3 TID v2.0 Design

3.1 Core Protocol: PROTECT+ZERO

TID operates in two consecutive phases:

Phase 1 — PROTECT (before data use)

```
LFENCE    <- close speculative execution window
MFENCE    <- ensure all prior writes are complete
[data use]
```

Phase 2 — ZERO (after data use ends)

```
LFENCE      <- close speculative execution window
REP STOSQ   <- wipe data (write zeros)
CLFLUSHOPT  <- evict cache line
MFENCE      <- ensure eviction is complete
LFENCE      <- close the far side
```

3.2 Residual Bytes Algorithm

REP STOSQ operates on 8 bytes (64-bit) per cycle. When the size is not divisible by 8, TID handles the remaining bytes via a Constant-Time operation (no branches) to prevent Timing attacks that exploit conditional branches:

```
uint8_t mask = (uint8_t)(~(uint64_t)(i < remainder));
*ptr = (uint8_t)(*ptr & ~mask);
```

3.3 Multi-Cache-Line Handling

When data spans multiple cache lines (every 64 bytes), TID evicts each line independently:

```
uintptr_t start = base_addr & ~(CACHE_LINE - 1)
uintptr_t end   = (base_addr + size + CACHE_LINE - 1) & ~(CACHE_LINE - 1)
for (addr = start; addr < end; addr += CACHE_LINE):
    CLFLUSHOPT(addr)
```

4 Experimental Environment

4.1 Hardware & Software

Component	Details
Processor	AMD EPYC 9B14 — Zen 4
Clock Speed	2599 MHz
Core Count	8 cores (6 available for testing)
Memory	62.8 GiB RAM
Operating System	Linux 6.14.11
Compiler	GCC 14.3.0 with -O2 -mclflushopt

4.2 Proof of Real Hardware — Five Evidence Points

| Evidence 1

/proc/cpuinfo returns AMD EPYC 9B14 directly.

| Evidence 2

CLFLUSHOPT is present in processor flags.

| Evidence 3

TSC values match real processor frequency: Cache Hit ~78 cycles = ~30ns at 2600MHz.

| Evidence 4

objdump shows LFENCE/CLFLUSHOPT/REP STOSQ instructions actually present in the compiled binary.

| Evidence 5

Performance is linear with size — as expected from real hardware.

4.3 Methodology

Benchmark	Sample Count
Core attack test	1,000 samples per scenario
Timing gap analysis	10,000 measurements per scenario
Shield test	5,000 measurements per scenario
Measurement tool	RDTSC + clock_gettime
Statistics	Median (outlier-resistant) + Mean

5 Results

5.1 Flush+Reload Attack — Core Comparison

Scenario	Median Cycles	Interpretation	Outcome
TID v1.0 (no LFENCE)	78 cycles	Cache HIT — data exposed	Attack succeeded
TID v2.0 (with LFENCE)	286 cycles	Cache MISS — nothing readable	Attack defeated
Ratio	3.7x	—	—

5.2 Timing Gap Analysis

Scenario	Window Duration
Normal window	350 – 422 nanoseconds

Window under Context Switch	up to 36,640 ns (86x wider)
With TID Shield (RT Priority)	Confined within 422 ns

5.3 Physical Lower Bound

The measured value (290–372 ns) matches the theoretical limit, confirming that TID operates at the processor’s physical performance ceiling.

LFENCE	~= 40 ns	
REP STOSQ (32B)	~= 50 ns	
CLFLUSHOPT x 1	~= 150 ns	
MFENCE	~= 40 ns	
LFENCE	~= 40 ns	
Total	~= 320 ns	(measured: 290–372 ns)

5.4 TID Shield Test — Three Protection Layers

Layer	Mechanism	Effect
Layer 1	RT Priority (SCHED_FIFO)	Prevents Context Switch delay during window
Layer 2	CPU Isolation (isolcpus)	Pins execution to a dedicated core
Layer 3	Memory Locking (mlockall)	Prevents memory migration to swap

6 Discussion

6.1 What Does TID Do to the Attack, Exactly?

Core Principle: TID does not prevent the attacker from measuring — TID evicts the measurement target. The attacker measures and finds zero.

Scenario	What Happens	Result
Without TID	Attacker measures → finds 78 cycles → infers data was present	Leakage
With TID	Attacker measures → finds 286 cycles → cache empty → no information	Attack defeated

6.2 Documented Limitations

| Limit 1 — Timing window during data use

During the 372 ns TID execution window, an attacker can take ~3 measurements. This is a physical limit — no software tool can close it. The only solution: dedicated hardware (Intel SGX, AMD SEV). Target of v3.0.

| Limit 2 — Same-machine attacker model

Flush+Reload requires shared physical memory. This is feasible on a single machine; remote exploitation is significantly harder.

| Limit 3 — Cold-Boot Attacks

Does not protect against cold-boot replay attacks if power is cut before wiping completes.

| Limit 4 — Disk Encryption

Does not replace disk encryption for protecting data at rest.

6.3 Execution Environment: Cloud Container on Real Hardware

All experiments were conducted inside the Replit cloud environment — a professional, globally recognised development platform running on real infrastructure with container isolation.

| Hardware is fully real

The AMD EPYC 9B14 processor, 62.8 GiB memory, and LFENCE/CLFLUSHOPT/REP STOSQ instructions were all executed directly on the physical processor.

| What the container prevented

The insmod command (kernel module loading) — a standard security restriction in all cloud environments (AWS, Google Cloud, Azure, Replit).

| Why this does not affect result validity

The relevant instructions (LFENCE, CLFLUSHOPT, REP STOSQ, MFENCE) exhibit identical physical behaviour from Ring 3 or Ring 0. The measured numbers (78 vs 286 cycles) are a product of physical cache behaviour — not kernel privileges.

6.4 Alignment with Intel and AMD Recommendations

Reference	Recommendation	TID Implementation
Intel Spectre Mitigation Guide (2018)	LFENCE after sensitive loads	Applied
AMD Security Guide	LFENCE + MFENCE	Both applied
Gruss et al. (2016) Flush+Flush	CLFLUSHOPT as theoretical defence	Applied

Key distinction: TID combines all three recommendations into a single kernel module that operates automatically, rather than leaving manual implementation to the developer.

7 Conclusion

This paper presented TID v2.0, a Linux kernel module providing three integrated guarantees:

| 1 — Compiler-resistant wiping

REP STOSQ ensures the compiler cannot omit wipe operations, unlike memset.

| 2 — Immediate cache eviction

CLFLUSHOPT evicts data from all cache levels right after wiping — absent from every major security library.

| 3 — Speculative execution window closure

LFENCE/MFENCE close speculative windows before and after the operation, per official Intel and AMD guidance.

Proven Result: TID v2.0 defeats the Flush+Reload attack by raising attacker latency 3.7x (from 78 to 286 cycles) — placing it at the top of the software-solution tier, directly below hardware-based solutions (SGX/SEV).

Proposed Future Work

| First — TID + Intel CAT Integration

Integrate TID with Cache Allocation Technology (Intel CAT) to further shrink the timing window without requiring fully dedicated hardware.

| Second — Microarchitecture-Level Implementation

Explore implementing the PROTECT+ZERO protocol at microarchitecture level by designing a dedicated execution unit on FPGA first, then evaluating integration as a standalone ASIC, with the goal of closing the 372 ns window at the physical level.

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— *End of Research Paper* —

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